

Website Accessibility Checklist

A practical WCAG 2.2-oriented review for making websites easier to perceive, operate, understand, and use with different devices and assistive technologies.

Start with the experience, not the score. Accessibility testing is not just running an automated scan and chasing a percentage. A site can pass many automated checks and still be frustrating or impossible for someone using a keyboard, screen reader, zoom, voice input, or a mobile device. Use this checklist to find real barriers in the journeys that matter.

What this checklist covers

The four WCAG principles are Perceivable, Operable, Understandable, and Robust. The checklist below turns those principles into concrete checks for content, navigation, forms, focus, media, responsive layouts, and dynamic interfaces.

Site / project: _____ Reviewer: _____

Date: _____ Target conformance: _____

Revision: September 2026

1. Page structure and semantics

A page should make sense when someone cannot rely on the visual design to explain the structure.

	Checklist item
☐	Every page has a useful, unique title and one clear primary page heading.
☐	Heading levels follow a logical outline; headings are not used only to make text look large.
☐	Header, navigation, main content, complementary content, and footer use meaningful landmarks where appropriate.
☐	Lists are marked up as lists, tables as tables, and grouped controls use appropriate semantics.
☐	A link takes the user to a destination; a button performs an action. Avoid clickable divs when a native element will do.
☐	The page language is identified in the HTML, and meaningful language changes are identified where needed.
☐	The DOM/source order still makes sense when read from top to bottom.

2. Keyboard access

Take the mouse away. This is one of the quickest ways to find problems that visual testing misses.

	Checklist item
☐	Every interactive control can be reached by keyboard.
☐	Tab order follows a sensible path and does not jump around unexpectedly.
☐	Keyboard focus is visible on links, buttons, form fields, and custom controls.
☐	Focused controls are not hidden beneath sticky headers, banners, cookie notices, or other overlays.
☐	Menus, dialogs, accordions, tabs, carousels, date pickers, and similar components have complete keyboard interaction.
☐	A dialog can be opened and closed with the keyboard, and focus returns to a sensible place when it closes.
☐	There is no keyboard trap.
☐	A skip link or comparable mechanism lets keyboard users bypass repeated navigation on longer pages.

3. Color, contrast, and visual presentation

Good visual design and accessibility are not opposites. The goal is to make the intended information survive the design treatment.

	Checklist item
☐	Normal text and important controls have sufficient contrast against their background.
☐	Information is never communicated by color alone.
☐	Links in blocks of text can be distinguished from surrounding text without relying only on color.
☐	The keyboard focus indicator is easy to see against the actual page background.
☐	Text remains usable when enlarged.
☐	Content reflows at narrow widths without creating avoidable two-dimensional scrolling.
☐	Important information does not disappear or become unusable when zoomed.

	Checklist item
☐	Text is real text whenever practical, rather than text baked into an image.

4. Images and non-text content

The right alt-text question is not “Does every image have words?” It is “What does this image contribute?”

	Checklist item
☐	Informative images have concise alt text that communicates the information a user needs.
☐	Decorative images are marked so assistive technology can ignore them.
☐	Images used as links or buttons have accessible names that describe the destination or action.
☐	Charts, diagrams, maps, and other complex visuals have a text alternative when their information matters.
☐	Alt text does not simply repeat a nearby caption or announce obvious decorative details.
☐	Product, service, team, and testimonial images have been reviewed for whether the surrounding copy already provides the needed information.

5. Forms and error handling

A form that looks clear to a sighted mouse user can still be difficult or impossible to complete with assistive technology.

	Checklist item
☐	Every field has a programmatically associated label.
☐	Placeholder text is not the only label or instruction.
☐	Required fields and important format requirements are communicated before or during entry.
☐	Common personal-information fields use appropriate autocomplete/autofill semantics.
☐	Validation errors identify the field and explain what needs to change.
☐	Errors are not communicated by red color alone.
☐	Keyboard users can quickly move from the error summary/message to the field that needs correction.
☐	User-entered information is preserved when practical after validation errors.
☐	Success messages are perceivable and clearly confirm that the submission worked.
☐	Form controls expose their state, such as expanded, checked, selected, disabled, or invalid, when the state changes.

6. Links, buttons, and controls

A person should be able to understand the important actions on a page without having to infer what an icon or generic label means.

	Checklist item
☐	Link text describes the destination or purpose in context.
☐	Repeated links are distinguishable when they lead to different places.

	Checklist item
☐	Buttons use labels that describe the action, such as "Save changes" or "Download checklist."
☐	Icon-only controls have an accessible name.
☐	Controls with changing state expose the state to assistive technology.
☐	Download links, new-window behavior, or unusual navigation are explained when the behavior is not obvious.

7. Motion, animation, and media

Animation can support a design, but it should never become a barrier to completing the task.

	Checklist item
☐	Autoplaying audio can be stopped or avoided; important audio does not start unexpectedly.
☐	Flashing or rapidly changing content has been reviewed for seizure/physical-reaction risks.
☐	Important information is not available only while an animation is moving.
☐	Non-essential motion can be reduced when the site provides motion-reduction behavior.
☐	Carousels, sliders, rotating testimonials, and animated menus have usable pause/stop or predictable controls where appropriate.
☐	Video has captions when spoken content matters.
☐	Meaningful audio/video content has alternatives appropriate to the information being conveyed.

8. Responsive and mobile accessibility

Responsive behavior is part of accessibility because controls, text, and reading order can change as the viewport changes.

	Checklist item
☐	The site remains usable at increased text size and zoom.
☐	Important controls are not hover-only.
☐	Touch targets are large enough and spaced well enough to reduce accidental activation.
☐	Drag-only interactions have another way to complete the same task.
☐	The page does not require one particular screen orientation unless there is a real need.
☐	Sticky elements and cookie/chat overlays do not cover the focused control or the content needed to complete the task.
☐	Forms remain usable with mobile keyboards, autocomplete, and touch input.

9. Dynamic content and JavaScript

A modern site may update content without reloading the page. Those changes still have to be understandable and operable.

	Checklist item
☐	Dynamically inserted content can be reached and announced when an announcement is necessary.

	Checklist item
☐	Expandable controls expose whether they are expanded or collapsed.
☐	Status messages and important asynchronous results are made perceivable without stealing focus.
☐	Single-page application route changes update the page title and manage focus sensibly.
☐	Custom widgets expose appropriate roles, accessible names, states, and keyboard behavior.
☐	Focus is not lost after AJAX submissions, validation, filters, or other asynchronous updates.
☐	Critical tasks do not depend on a JavaScript behavior that has no usable fallback when the dependency fails.

10. Reading order, language, and comprehension

Assistive technology often follows the document structure rather than the visual arrangement you designed.

	Checklist item
☐	Reading order matches the intended meaning when content is read linearly.
☐	CSS positioning does not create a confusing or contradictory reading sequence.
☐	Instructions are written in plain enough language for the intended audience.
☐	Unusual abbreviations, technical terms, and required steps are explained where the reader needs them.
☐	Links and controls still make sense when announced without the surrounding visual context.
☐	Long pages use headings and other navigation aids that help users move through sections.

11. Testing: automation plus human review

Accessibility testing works best as a combination. Automated tools find patterns; people verify meaning, interaction, and the actual task.

	Checklist item
☐	Run an automated accessibility scan on representative page types.
☐	Review every automated finding and confirm whether it is a real issue.
☐	Perform a keyboard-only pass through the site's most important user journey.
☐	Test a representative page with a screen reader and browser combination used by the team.
☐	Test zoom/text enlargement and reflow rather than relying only on a responsive screenshot.
☐	Test forms with both successful and failed submissions.
☐	Manually test custom widgets such as menus, dialogs, tabs, accordions, carousels, and date inputs.
☐	Record defects with the URL/component, observed barrier, expected behavior, and priority.

12. Accessibility release review

Accessibility is part of the release process, not a one-time cleanup task.

	Checklist item
☐	Critical task blockers have been fixed or explicitly accepted by the project owner.
☐	Keyboard review has covered the main pages and conversion paths.
☐	Forms and interactive components have passed manual keyboard testing.
☐	Contrast and visible focus have been checked on the production design.
☐	Content editors know how to create accessible headings, links, images, and documents.
☐	PDFs, videos, infographics, and other downloadable content have an accessibility plan.
☐	Third-party widgets used on important pages have been checked and do not block core tasks.
☐	The site has a practical way for visitors to report accessibility problems.
☐	The team has documented the target WCAG version/conformance target and any known exceptions.

Accessibility quick test: 10 minutes, no tools

This is the fastest human check to perform on any important page.

	Checklist item
☐	Put the mouse away and use Tab, Shift+Tab, Enter, Space, and Escape. Can you reach and operate everything important?
☐	Can you always tell where keyboard focus is?
☐	Can you tell what each link or button will do without guessing?
☐	Turn on a screen reader. Can you understand the page heading, landmarks, headings, links, buttons, and form labels?
☐	Zoom the page significantly. Does the content remain readable and usable?
☐	Complete the most important form using only the keyboard.
☐	Trigger a validation error. Can you tell what went wrong and how to fix it?
☐	Open a menu, modal, accordion, or other component. Can you operate it and get back to where you were?
☐	Look away from the screen briefly. Does any essential information rely only on color, animation, or visual placement?
☐	Have someone unfamiliar with the site complete the main task without coaching. Note every place they hesitate.

A note about conformance

WCAG 2.2 is a technical standard, not a guarantee that every person will find a site easy to use. A strong review combines standards-based testing with real task testing. Automated accessibility scanners are helpful, but they cannot determine every issue involving meaning, context, keyboard behavior, focus management, or whether alternative text actually communicates the right information.

Primary reference: W3C Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2.

<https://www.w3.org/TR/wcag/>

Supporting reference: W3C WCAG 2.2 Overview and WCAG at a Glance.

<https://www.w3.org/WAI/standards-guidelines/wcag/> | <https://www.w3.org/WAI/standards-guidelines/wcag/glance/>

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